B1 Grammar

# Present perfect or past simple?

When to use 'I have done' and when to use 'I did', with clear signal words.

Both tenses talk about the past. The difference is whether the past is **finished and dated** or **connected to now**.

| Past simple | Present perfect |
|---|---|
| A finished time: *yesterday, in 2019, last week, two days ago* | Unfinished time or no time given: *today, this year, ever, never, yet, already, so far* |
| *I lost my keys yesterday.* | *I've lost my keys. (I still can't find them.)* |
| *She lived in Paris for five years. (She doesn't now.)* | *She has lived in Paris for five years. (She still does.)* |

## Form

Present perfect: `have / has + past participle`. Past simple: `verb + -ed` or the irregular past form.

> **Quick test.** If you can add a finished time expression such as *last year*, use the past simple.

> **Common mistake.** Do not say *I have seen him yesterday.* Say *I saw him yesterday.*

## Practice

1. I ___ (never / try) sushi.
2. We ___ (move) to this city in 2018.
3. ___ you ___ (finish) your homework yet?
4. He ___ (break) his leg last winter.
5. They ___ (be) married for ten years, and they are still very happy.

▼ **Show answers**

1. have never tried
2. moved
3. Have you finished
4. broke
5. have been